

RANRAN LI

Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security and Law
Günterstalstraße 73, 79100 Freiburg im Breisgau

Website: ranranli.net; Email: r.li@csl.mpg.de

[Website](#) | [MPI webpage](#) | [Google Scholar](#) | [ORCID](#) | [LinkedIn](#)

ACADEMIC POSITION

2025 – Postdoctoral researcher (Humboldt Postdoc Fellow since 2026)
Department of Criminology, Host: Jean-Louis van Gelder
Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security and Law, Germany

EDUCATION

2020 – 2025 PhD in Personality Psychology
Dissertation: Unlocking Personality: How situational strength and situational affordances shape behavioral expression (Supervisors: Reinout E. de Vries, Daniel Balliet, Isabel Thielmann). <https://doi.org/10.5463/thesis.1256>
Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, Netherlands

2024 – 25 PhD research visit, *Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security, and Law*

2018 – 2020 Research Master's in Psychology (with merit)
University of Amsterdam, Netherlands

2016 – 17 Global Exchange, *University of Münster, Germany*

2014 – 2018 BSc in Psychology (distinction)
Soochow University, Taiwan

RESEARCH STATEMENT

With the belief that ‘*Serious inquiry into human nature is not a luxury*,’ I study how personality traits and situational factors interact to shape human behavior, in particular, prosocial and moral behavior. I am currently applying this **person–situation interaction perspective** to the study of bystander intervention (i.e., how people remain prosocial when situations make it difficult to do so). I adopt rigorous empirical methods and am drawn to theoretical integration.

While psychology remains my ‘*Forever Moonlight*’ and intellectual foundation, I have interdisciplinary interests and pursuits. At present, I am actively bridging psychology with criminology, behavioral economics, and sociocultural perspectives. I am additionally interested in philosophy of science (meta-science) and computational social science. I see myself as a bridge and builder across disciplines.

Support good science – open, rigorous, and trustworthy science – always on the way.

PUBLICATIONS

2026

Li, R., De Vries, R. E., Van Gelder, J.-L. (2026). Entangled pathways to delinquency: An integrative process model of personality, situations, and macro-structures. *Zeitschrift für Psychologie*.

◇ Co-organizing a panel at the European Society of Criminology (ESC), Warsaw, Sept 2026, "Virtual Reality as a window into crime: Personality, situations, and psychological processes"

{person-situation processes}

Ye, Z., Long, F., Feng, R., van Dijk, W., & **Li, R.** (2026). People feel but don't tell: Dispositional honesty and emotional responses to others' (mis)fortunes. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, 126, 104966. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2026.104966>

{empathy, prosociality, morality}

{method: vignette; diary; real-time interaction}

De Vries, R. E., & **Li, R.** (forthcoming; commentary). Superfluous states, facet fallacies, and psychometric problems in the Whole Trait Theory. *European Journal of Personality*.

2025

Li, R., & Wilt, J. A. (2025). Situated selves: A cyclical model of personality expression in context. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 102104. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2025.102104>

{person-situation processes}

Van Gelder, J.-L., **Li, R.**, Wiechert, S., & Frankenhuys, W. E. (2025). Short-term mindsets: Beyond traits and self-regulation. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 102112. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2025.102112>

Li, R., & Zettler, I. (2025). Entangled Minds: A roadmap for bridging cultural and personality psychology research. *Personality Science*, 6. <https://doi.org/10.1177/27000710251388772>

{personality x cultural psychology}

Li, R., Thielmann, I., Balliet, D., & De Vries, R. E. (2025). Trait activation in daily life: Comparing two perspectives on person-situation interactions. *Journal of Research in Personality*, 104689. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrp.2025.104689>

◇ Received SeedCorn Research Grant €3,000 for the project, Kurt Lewin Institute

◇ Organized a symposium at the International Convention of Psychological Science (ICPS), Brussels, Mar 2023, "Trait and situation activation in daily life and organizational settings"

{person-situation processes}

{method: diary study}

2024

Li, R., Balliet, D., Thielmann, I., & De Vries, R. E. (2024). Revisiting situational strength: Do strong situations restrict variance in behaviors? *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*. <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspi0000475>

◇ Received multiple awards for the paper, including Best Paper Award @ Dutch Work & Organizational Psychology conference, Tilburg, Netherlands (2022), Runner-up for the Best Paper Award, Kurt Lewin Institute, Netherlands (2024), and Best Student Presentation Award at the International Conference on Social Dilemmas, Leiden, Netherlands (2024).

◇ Chaired a methodological session “Methodological Advances in OB research” at the Academy of Management (AOM), Boston, Aug 2023:

{person-situation processes; prosocial behavior}
{method: social dilemma games; meta-analysis}

2023

Li, R., Thielmann, I., Balliet, D., & De Vries, R. E. (2023). Development of the Generic Situational Strength (GSS) scale: Measuring situational strength across contexts. In L. R. Ford & T. A. Scandura (Eds.), *The SAGE Handbook of Survey Development and Application*.
<https://doi.org/10.4135/9781529617757.n35>

{method: scale development}

Li, R. Revisiting person–situation interactionism. *Nature Reviews Psychology*, 2, 6 (2023).
<https://doi.org/10.1038/s44159-022-00139-8>

{person-situation processes}

> Manuscripts in the pipeline

Li, R., Thielmann, I., Balliet, D., & De Vries, R. (R&R 2nd round). When dishonesty pays off: Incentives foster trait activation of Honesty-Humility.

◇ Received iBBA Online Experiment Grant €2,500, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam

{person-situation processes; dishonesty}
{method: experimental cheating games}

Li, R., Knabe, M., Derakhshan, S., Arui, A.-K., & Van Gelder, J.-L. (under review). Beyond immersion and presence: Rethinking validity in Virtual Reality criminology.

{method: Virtual Reality}

He, Y., & **Li, R.** (under review). Helping in the dark: Toward a science of prosociality under risk.

He, Y., & **Li, R.** (under review). Prosociality under risk: A conceptual synthesis and roadmap for future research.

{prosocial behavior}

> Work in progress

Li, R., De Vries, R. E., Barnum, T., Herman, S., Tisdall, L., Van Gelder, J.-L. A trait–state model of reactive guardianship: Psychological pathways to bystander intervention. *Manuscript in prep.*

{bystander intervention}
{method: Virtual Reality}

Li, R., Van Gelder, J.-L., & De Vries, R. E. Who goes where and why? A meta-analytic review of personality and situation selection. *Manuscript in prep.*

{person-situation processes}
{method: meta-analysis}

Umashev, N., **Li, R.**, Rusch, H. Agent incentives: How agents trade off incentives and exploitation risk in principal selection. *Manuscript in prep.*

{personality; exploitation}
{method: sequential experimental games}

van Lissa, C., Ballou, N., **Li, R.**, et al. Self-determination theory: Theory specification. *Manuscript in prep.*

{method: formal theory}

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Slides/posters available at osf.io/a83tv

Panel Co-organizer: European Society of Criminology (ESC), Warsaw, Sept 2026: “Virtual Reality as a window into crime: Personality, situations, and psychological processes”

Symposium Organizer: International Convention of Psychological Science (ICPS), Brussels, Mar 2023: “Trait and situation activation in daily life and organizational settings”

Session Moderator: Academy of Management (AOM), Boston, Aug 2023: “Methodological Advances in OB Research”

Other presentations (selected):

(Personality) Psychology	European Conference of Personality (ECP) ^{1,2,3} ; Association for Research in Personality (ARP) conference; Differentielle Psychologie (DPPD) conference; Chinese Personality Psychology conference Kurt Lewin Institute (KLI) Conference; German Psychological Science Congress (DGPs);	¹ Edinburgh, July 2026; ² Berlin, Aug 2024; ³ Madrid, Aug 2022; Evanston, July 2023; Kassel, Sept 2025; Beijin, Dec 2024; Utrecht, April 2024; Luxembourg, Sept 2026; Warsaw, Sept 2026 Washington DC, Nov 2025
Criminology	European Society of Criminology (ESC) conference; American Society of Criminology (ASC) conference;	
Behavioral Economics/ Interdisciplinary	International Conference on Social Dilemmas (ICSD); Cognition, Behavior, & Evolution Network (CBEN) conference ^{1,2} ; Matterhorn Symposium;	Leiden, July 2024; ¹ Maastricht, Oct 2024; ² Leiden, April 2026; Brig, Switzerland, Sept 2025;
Management	Academy of Management (AOM) conference; Working community of Dutch Work & Organizational Psychology (WAOP) ^{1,2} ,	Boston 2023; ¹ Tilburg, Nov 2022; ² Groningen, Nov 2023;
Others: VR, Tech	XR meeting; VIRTUES VR meeting; Machine+Behavior conference.	Würzburg, Oct 2025; Hagen, Sept 2025; Berlin, May 2026.

CONTINUED LEARNING

Substantive

Summer School of Personality Science (SSPS). *Madrid, Aug 2022.*

Summer School of the European Society of Criminology (ESC). *Lausanne, June 2025.*

Small Group Meeting “Beyond the blur of self-regulation research”. *Graz, June 2026.*

Spring School “Experimental research moral judgement & (un)ethical behavior”. *Wittenberg, Mar 2026.*

Small Group Meeting “The future of behavioral ethics: Social perspectives on dishonesty. *Berlin, May 2025.*

Workshop Philosophy of Science. *Freiburg, Feb 2025.*

Methodology

Summer Institute Computational Social Science (SICSS-ODISSEI). *Rotterdam, June 2022.*

Modeling the dynamics of intensive longitudinal data. *Utrecht, Aug 2022.*

BEHAVE Agent-based modeling summer school. *Aug 2021, online.*

Methodological seminars. *April 2021, online.*

Big data analytics. *Fall 2019 (selective ResMas), Amsterdam.*

Network analysis. *Fall 2019 (selective ResMas), Amsterdam.*

Bayesian inference and analysis. *Fall 2019, Amsterdam; Oct 2021, online.*

Writing

Bayesian inference and analysis. *Fall 2019, Amsterdam; Oct 2021, online.*

Scientific writing workshop. *Freiburg, Oct 2024.*

Creativity workshop. *New York, July 2023.*

GRANTS, AWARDS

Grants/Fellowships

2026	Humboldt Postdoc Fellowship: two-year fellowship (approx. €90k)
2025	Chinese Government Award for Outstanding PhDs: \$6,000
2024	DAAD (German Academic Exchange Service) Research Grant: Bi-nationally Supervised Doctoral Degrees, €1,300*7 months
2024	iBBA Online Experiment Grant €2,500, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam
2021	Kurt Lewin Institute (KLI) SeedCorn Research Grant €3,000

Awards

2024	Best Student Presentation Award , International Conference on Social Dilemmas (ICSD), Leiden, Netherlands
2024	Runner-up for the Best Paper Award , Kurt Lewin Institute, Netherlands
2022	Best Paper Award , Working community of Dutch Work & Organizational Psychology (WAOP) conference, Tilburg, Netherlands

Scholarship

2024	Travel Grant European Conference of Personality (ECP)
------	---

2023	Academy of Management (AOM) conference registration scholarship
2017	DAAD (German Grant Institute) - STIBET fellowship
2014 - 2018	Soochow University Scholarship for students with outstanding academic performance (*7 times); Franklin Scholarships for Dual Degree of Soochow University (*3 times). Sum up to NT\$ 400,000 ($\approx$ 12,680€)

REVIEWING

Personality and Social Psychology Review: *Emerging Editorial Board* (2023–2025; 4);
European Journal of Personality (4);
Collabra: Psychology (1);
Health Psychology (1);
Zeitschrift für Psychologie (1);
Current Research in Ecological and Social Psychology (1);
Social Psychology (1);
European Journal on Criminal Policy and Research (1);
SAGE Handbook of Survey Development and Application (1).

TEACHING

Mentorship	BOGY internship student Alina Schwalbe (10th-grade), April 2026, <i>Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security and Law</i> .
Journal club host	Grant proposal writing. June 2026, <i>Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security and Law</i> .
Thesis supervision	Master thesis supervision and assessment, <i>Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam</i> . Sebastiaan Schulter (2023–2024), Savannah Huxtable (2023–2024), Daria Hovorukha (student from Ukraine, 2022–2023), Lara Vogel (2022–2023), Zihan Wang (2022–2023), Chenyu Tang (2021–2022), Sofia Canelos (2021–2022), Nora Choa (2020–2022). Bachelor thesis supervision, <i>Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam</i> Roe Bakker (2021–2022).
Guest Lecture	Invited Guest Lecture “Personality in Organizational Settings”, Feb 2024, <i>Amsterdam Business School, University of Amsterdam</i> .
Grading	Grading master’s course ‘Personality at Work’, <i>Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam</i> Grading bachelor’s course ‘Methodological Research Projects’, <i>University of Amsterdam, Amsterdam Business School</i> .

SCIENCE COMMUNICATION

Translations for cross-cultural projects @*Psychological Science Accelerator* (and colleagues) to enhance the generalizability of psychological science.

Speaker: Inspiration stage talk @*Berlin Science Week* (Nov 2026, expected). Would you step in? The science of bystander courage.

Columnist: Promote science communication in personality-social psychology, promote methodological rigor in scientific practices. Selected blogs include:

- ❖ The Soul of Science: On integrity in an age of pragmatic academia. (2025).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/soul-of-science.html> (English).
- ❖ How situational settings influence behavior: New insights from behavioral research. (2024). Kudos: American Psychological Association (APA) showcases.
<https://www.growkudos.com/publications/10.1037%252Fpspi0000475/>
- ❖ Recent Development in Personality Assessment. (2022). Amsterdam Leadership Lab.
<https://www.amsterdamleadershiplab.nl/recent-development-in-personality-assessment>
- ❖ AOM 2020 Reflections: Insights from the Academy of Management Annual Meeting. (2020).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/aom2020.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/iVOEuHauUwGY9PTO7S6aSw> (Chinese)
- ❖ The Limitations of p -value and Bayesian hypothesis testing. (2019).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/pvalue-bayes.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/sTBc3Yvd7aBpFt4Dmt7r9Q> (Chinese).
- ❖ Big Data Analytics in Psychology and Management Research. (2020).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/bigdata.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/zg01AE3mKxQ7HWQkwTtBDA> (Chinese).
- ❖ Is Psychology a useless discipline? (2020) (Chinese)
- ❖ Questionable Research Practices (QRPs) in Social Science Research. (2021).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/qtps.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/1fDl5gUYtRjIs2bHHXJmBA> (Chinese)